Recruitment and Hiring Procedure

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Summary. Sets out the steps for hiring at Northstar Systems from requisition approval through sourcing, interview panels, offers, background verification and joining, including approval limits, the 7-day offer validity, the employee referral bonus and candidate data retention.

SYNTHETIC DOCUMENT - Northstar Systems is a fictional company. This document exists for development, testing and demonstration only and is not real legal, employment, security or compliance advice.

1. Purpose and Scope

This procedure describes how Northstar Systems Private Limited opens positions, finds and selects candidates, makes offers and prepares new employees to join. It aims to hire capable people quickly, fairly and in a way that is consistent across Engineering, IT and Security, Operations and Procurement, Customer Success and Support, and Human Resources. It sets clear approval points so that headcount, budget and pay decisions are made by the right people.

The procedure applies to all permanent, fixed-term and intern hires in Bands B1 to B7 in Bengaluru, Mumbai and remote locations in India, including internal transfers into a vacancy and rehires. Contractors and consultants engaged through a vendor are covered by the procurement rules in the Purchase Approval Policy (OPS-001) and not by this procedure. After the offer is accepted, the Employee Onboarding Procedure (HR-005) takes over; pay and offer structure rules are in the Compensation, Payroll and Salary Revision Policy (HR-010).

The recruitment team uses **NorthPeople**, the HRMS, to record requisitions, candidate stages and onboarding tasks. Budget checks use cost-centre codes such as CC-ENG-### and CC-CS-###, and headcount approvals follow the budget in the Budget Planning and Cost Center Policy (OPS-008).

2. Definitions

- **Requisition**: the formal request to fill a position, raised in NorthPeople.
- **Approved headcount**: positions funded in the annual budget or approved as an addition during the year.
- **Hiring manager**: the manager to whom the new hire will report.
- **Talent Acquisition (TA)**: the team led by the Head of Talent Acquisition that sources, screens and coordinates hiring.
- **Interview panel**: the group of interviewers who assess a candidate.

- **Bar raiser**: an interviewer from outside the hiring team who checks that hiring standards are held.
- **Background verification (BGV)**: checks on identity, education, employment history and, for some roles, criminal record or references, done by an external agency.
- **Offer letter**: the written offer of employment, stating Band, fixed pay, variable pay target, joining date and conditions.
- **Referral**: a candidate recommended by a current employee.

3. Roles and Responsibilities

Role	Responsibility
Hiring manager	Defines the role, raises the requisition, shortlists, interviews, makes the hire decision, owns onboarding plan
Department head	Approves the requisition and the offer within their authority
Finance (Finance Controller)	Confirms budget and cost centre for the requisition
Head of Talent Acquisition	Owns this procedure, manages recruiters, agencies and sourcing channels
Recruiter	Runs the process, schedules interviews, collects feedback, manages candidate communication
Interviewers	Prepare, assess against criteria, submit written feedback within 1 business day
HR Business Partner	Reviews offers for pay consistency and Band fit
Payroll and Benefits Manager	Checks salary against Band range and prepares compensation details
Chief People Officer	Approves exceptions and offers requiring HR approval above the standard level
CEO	Approves offers above Band B5

4. Opening a Position

4.1 Requisition

The hiring manager raises a requisition in NorthPeople with: the job title, Band, number of positions, location (Bengaluru, Mumbai or remote), reason for hiring (new, replacement, backfill), required skills, the cost centre and the expected start date. The reason must be clear; for a replacement the name of the person who left and their last working day are recorded.

4.2 Approval

A requisition needs approval from the department head and from Finance before any search begins. The department head confirms the business need, and Finance confirms that headcount is funded in the budget or that the department has approved additional budget through the correct route. A requisition for a position not in the approved budget is an unbudgeted cost; when the annual cost exceeds INR 1,00,000 above plan, the CFO must also approve, following the Delegation of Authority. Roles for fully remote work must additionally be approved by the VP of the function and the Chief People Officer.

Nobody may advertise a position, speak to agencies or make any promise to a candidate before the requisition is approved. Where a candidate has already been identified, the requisition must still be raised and approved before an offer is discussed.

4.3 Internal first

TA posts approved roles on the internal job board for at least 5 working days before or at the same time as external advertising. Employees who have completed at least 12 months in their current role and have a rating of 3 or higher in the last cycle may apply with their manager's knowledge. The manager must not block a transfer without a business reason, but may agree a handover period of up to 60 days.

5. Sourcing

5.1 Channels

TA sources candidates through the careers page, professional networks, job boards, campus programmes, employee referrals, and preferred recruitment agencies. Agencies must be onboarded in NorthBuy as vendors with a signed agreement and a conflict-of-interest declaration before they may submit candidates. Agency fees are paid only for a hire completed through the agreement, and any candidate already in the system within the last 6 months is not eligible for a fee. Agency invoices follow the Delegation of Authority and Purchase Approval Policy (OPS-001).

5.2 Employee referrals

Employees are encouraged to refer people they know and trust. A referral is submitted in NorthPeople with the candidate's consent. The referrer is not involved in the evaluation. Referral bonuses are:

Referred hire Band	Bonus
B1 to B4	INR 25,000
B5 and above	INR 50,000

The bonus is paid after the referred hire completes 6 months of service. It is paid with the next payroll in NorthPay after the 6-month date, subject to tax deduction at source. The referrer must still be employed on the payment date. Members of Talent Acquisition, the hiring manager for the role and anyone in the direct reporting chain above the vacancy are not eligible for a referral bonus for that role. If two employees refer the same candidate, the earlier recorded referral is eligible. Referrals of relatives are allowed but must be disclosed as set out in the Code of Conduct and Ethics (HR-008), and the relative must not be in the reporting line.

5.3 Fair and inclusive sourcing

Job descriptions must use plain language, list only requirements that are truly necessary and avoid wording that discourages any group. Northstar does not discriminate on the grounds of gender, caste, religion, language, age, disability, marital status or any other protected characteristic. TA reports on the diversity of shortlists and hires to the Chief People Officer each quarter.

6. Screening and Interviews

6.1 Screening

The recruiter screens applications against the requisition and conducts a short call to check availability, location, notice period, expected pay and interest. Pay history may not be demanded as a condition; candidates are asked for expectations. The hiring manager reviews shortlisted profiles within 2 business days.

6.2 Interview panel

Each candidate is interviewed by a panel of at least 3 interviewers, and at least one of them must be from outside the hiring team. The panel should include a mix of technical or functional depth, a view on collaboration and values and, for Band B4 and above, a manager-level discussion. Interviewers must have completed the interviewer training in NorthLearn. No interviewer may be a relative of the candidate or have a conflict of interest. Panel members must declare any prior working or personal relationship with the candidate to the recruiter before the interview.

6.3 Structured evaluation

Interviewers assess candidates against agreed criteria for the role and record scores and written comments in NorthPeople within 1 business day of the interview, before talking with other interviewers, to avoid influence. The recruiter then facilitates a debrief. A hire decision requires a majority of interviewers to support the hire and no unresolved concern from the panel member from outside the hiring team. The final decision belongs to the hiring manager, but a hire may not go ahead if the outside interviewer records a strong concern unless the department head and the Head of Talent Acquisition review and approve it in writing.

6.4 Assessments

For Engineering roles, a practical exercise or live problem-solving session may be used. Take-home assignments must not exceed 3 hours of expected effort and must not use real customer data. For roles that handle customer escalations or financial transactions, a role-play or case discussion may be used. Candidates who need reasonable adjustments, for example because of a disability, must be provided with them on request.

6.5 Candidate experience

Candidates should receive an acknowledgement within 3 working days of applying, and an update after each stage within 5 working days. Candidates who are not selected are told respectfully and promptly. Interviewers must not ask questions about marital status, family plans, religion, caste, political views or health that are not relevant to the job.

7. References and Background Verification

7.1 Background verification is mandatory

A background verification is mandatory for every new employee. Background verification must be completed satisfactorily before the joining date is confirmed, and the offer is conditional on a satisfactory result. The BGV covers identity and address, education, previous employment for at least the last two employers, and any other checks appropriate to the role. Roles in Finance, IT and Security with access to Restricted data and any role at Band B6 and above may also have a criminal record check, performed with the candidate's written consent.

The candidate must submit documents and consent through the BGV agency's portal within 3 working days of accepting the offer. The agency is expected to finish most checks within 10 working days; delays are managed by the recruiter.

7.2 Outcomes

- **Clear**: the joining date is confirmed and onboarding proceeds.

- **Minor discrepancy**: for example a small difference in dates of employment. The recruiter asks the candidate for an explanation and supporting documents, and the HR Business Partner decides.
- **Major discrepancy**: for example a fake degree, concealed termination, or a false identity. The offer is withdrawn and the case is referred to the General Counsel. If the employee has already joined, the matter is handled as misconduct under HR-014.

A candidate must not be allowed to join, and must not be given system access, before the joining date is confirmed. There is no conditional joining while BGV is pending, and the BGV requirement may not be waived for any Band.

8. Offers

8.1 Preparing the offer

The recruiter and hiring manager propose the Band, fixed pay and variable target. The Payroll and Benefits Manager checks the proposal against the Band range, existing employees in similar roles and the budget. A new hire is normally offered between the Band minimum and midpoint. The HR Business Partner confirms that the offer is consistent and does not create inequity.

8.2 Approval levels

Offer	Approval needed
Within Band range, Band B1 to B3	Hiring manager, HR Business Partner
Within Band range, Band B4 and B5	Department head, HR Business Partner, Payroll and Benefits Manager
Above the Band midpoint	Department head and Chief People Officer
Above Band B5 (Band B6 and B7)	CEO, in addition to the above

Offers above Band B5 need CEO approval in every case. An offer must not be extended verbally or by email before approval is complete.

8.3 Offer letter and validity

The offer letter states the position, Band, location, fixed pay, variable target, joining date, probation of 6 months, notice periods, conditions such as BGV, and references to relevant policies. The offer letter is valid for 7 calendar days from the date it is issued. If the candidate does not accept in writing within the 7 calendar days, the offer lapses. An extension of up to 3 further days may be granted once by the Head of Talent Acquisition for a good reason, and must be confirmed in writing. After acceptance, the candidate must resign from the current employer and share the resignation proof, if requested.

Example: TA issues an offer to a Band B4 Technical Lead on Tuesday 10 March. The offer lapses at the end of Monday 16 March. The candidate asks on Sunday for 4 extra days because of a competing offer. The Head of Talent Acquisition may grant an extension of at most 3 days, to 19 March, and confirms it in writing.

8.4 Counter-offers and negotiation

If a candidate asks for more pay, the recruiter takes the request to the hiring manager and HR Business Partner. A revised offer within the approved range may be made once. Offers must not be increased in a way that creates inequity with existing employees in the same role, and any increase is approved again at the correct level in 8.2. If the candidate receives a counter-offer from

the current employer, Northstar does not engage in a bidding contest.

8.5 Joining date

The joining date is normally on the first or the third Monday of the month, or another date agreed with the recruiter, so that onboarding sessions and access set-up can be planned. Most employees join within the notice period of their current employer; TA should not pressure a candidate to leave before the end of the notice period.

9. Transition to Onboarding

After acceptance and a clear BGV, the recruiter creates the joiner record in NorthPeople. This triggers the onboarding tasks in HR-005 for IT access, laptop allocation, payroll set-up, training and first-day schedule. The hiring manager must confirm the buddy and the first-week plan at least 5 working days before the joining date. The IT Service Desk prepares a laptop and accounts so that access is ready on day 1, as described in the Access Management Policy (SEC-002).

10. Special Cases

10.1 Rehires

A former employee who left in good standing and has a rating of 3 or above in the last cycle may be rehired after a gap of at least 6 months, with approval from the department head and the Head of Talent Acquisition. Previous service does not reset probation unless the Chief People Officer approves otherwise. Employees who were terminated for misconduct are not rehired.

10.2 Internal transfers

An internal candidate is evaluated with the same process. The current manager is informed after the first interview. If selected, the transfer takes effect after the handover period, and the new Band and pay follow HR-010. Leave and tenure are carried forward.

10.3 Interns and fixed-term hires

Interns are hired on a fixed-term agreement of up to 6 months, with a stipend set by HR. Conversion of an intern to a permanent role needs a new requisition and approval. Fixed-term employees follow the same BGV rule and receive an offer letter stating the end date.

10.4 Hiring relatives and conflicts

A relative of an employee may be hired only if the person is not in the same reporting chain and if the conflict is disclosed in line with HR-008. The employee must not take part in the process.

10.5 Urgent hiring

Where there is a business-critical need, the Head of Talent Acquisition may speed up the process, for example by running interviews on the same day. The panel size, outside interviewer, approvals and BGV requirements may not be waived.

11. Records and Data Protection

Candidate information is personal data and must be used only for recruitment. Recruitment records of unsuccessful candidates, including applications, interview notes and assessments, are kept for 12 months and then deleted or anonymised, unless a legal hold applies or the candidate has

consented to be kept for future roles. Records of hired employees move to the employee record and are kept for 7 years after exit. Candidate files must not be sent through personal email or stored on personal devices. Interview notes must be factual and professional because candidates may have a right to request their data under the privacy rules (illustrative; to be verified by Legal).

12. Metrics

TA reports each month to the Chief People Officer on time to fill, offer acceptance rate, source mix, cost per hire, referral share, diversity of hires and 6-month retention of new hires. The target for the time from approved requisition to accepted offer is 45 days for Band B1 to B4 roles, which is a goal and not a guarantee.

13. Frequently Asked Questions

Can I tell a friend about an opening before the requisition is approved? You may suggest that they follow the careers page, but you may not promise a job or discuss pay. The requisition must be approved before any process starts.

How long do I have to accept an offer? The offer letter is valid for 7 calendar days, with a possible single extension of up to 3 days.

When is the referral bonus paid? After the referred hire completes 6 months. It is INR 25,000 for Band B1 to B4 hires and INR 50,000 for Band B5 and above.

Can a new hire start work before the background check is clear? No. The joining date is confirmed only after BGV is completed with a satisfactory result.

14. Related Documents

See the Employee Onboarding Procedure (HR-005) for activities after acceptance, the Compensation, Payroll and Salary Revision Policy (HR-010) for pay structure, and the Purchase Approval Policy (OPS-001) for engaging recruitment agencies and the Delegation of Authority.

15. Revision History

Version	Date	Change
3.5	2024-08-19	Introduced outside-team interviewer rule
4.0	2025-04-07	Added referral bonus table and BGV completion rule
4.1	2025-12-19	Clarified offer validity, approval table and candidate data retention